

HomeConnect One — Consulting Brief

Project-4 Silver Trust · 1-page brief · discovery interview findings and recommendations

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Company context

HomeConnect One is a medium-sized German smart home consultation, integration, and management company, founded by a non-technical owner who was an early pioneer in the industry. It does not manufacture devices; it connects smart heating, energy monitoring, EV chargers, solar PV, and third-party products into a single platform for residential clients. Growth is driven by German energy-efficiency mandates, rising energy prices, and environmental awareness, and the client base has shifted from tech-savvy early adopters to a broader, less technical audience. The company's stated priority is operational efficiency, not revenue growth — growth is already happening on its own.

Problem 1: Manual ticket triage is consuming the product team

Less than 20% of the product team's time goes to actual roadmap work — the rest is spent manually classifying every incoming ticket (chat, forum, email, installer feedback) as a support issue, software defect, or roadmap request before it reaches the right team. This causes multi-day delays and over a month to resolve new product issues, and worsens with every new device type added. HomeConnect's own team estimates that doubling third-party API integrations next year — their stated growth direction — would overwhelm this process and force a product redesign they don't have bandwidth for.

Problem 2: No visibility into installer availability and capability

Installation is outsourced through a non-exclusive agency, and HomeConnect has no oversight tooling for which installers are available, where, and with what specialization. Installers sometimes commit and fail to deliver, or arrive and turn out unsuited for the job — causing customer complaints that make already-frustrated customers more likely to escalate later.

Recommended solutions

- 1. Ticket triage:** An AI-assisted classification and routing layer on top of the team's existing triage logic — ingesting tickets, matching against device metadata and historical resolution patterns, and auto-routing straightforward cases while surfacing only ambiguous ones for human review.
- 2. Installer oversight:** A lightweight installer management dashboard tracking availability, specialization, geographic coverage, and active assignments — giving the product team a single source of truth instead of ad hoc outreach.

Why they fit

Both use data or relationships HomeConnect already has — ticket history and device specs for the first, existing agency relationships for the second — rather than requiring new infrastructure, new hires, or the full product redesign the team says it can't currently afford. Both preserve current decision authority (the product team, the technical lead, the owner) rather than replacing judgment with automation.

Risks and mitigations

Novel or ambiguous tickets: automated triage may misclassify genuinely new issue types as device variety grows — mitigated by routing low-confidence cases to human review rather than forcing a classification. **Installer data quality:** the oversight dashboard is only as good as the availability/specialization data the agency provides — an initial data-cleanup step is needed before the pilot starts. **Team bandwidth for rollout:** since the team already lacks time for a full redesign, both pilots are scoped as additive tools rather than workflow overhauls, minimizing setup load.

Next step

A short pilot on both fronts in parallel: (1) triage automation on 2–3 top device categories, measured by time-to-correct-routing and resolution-time change; (2) a simple installer tracking view populated from existing agency data, measured by reduction in failed/late installations. Suggested pilot length: 4–6 weeks, reviewed in the team's existing daily cross-functional meeting so the owner and technical lead see progress in the format they already use for decisions.

Note: network/router-level issues and DIY self-serve demand are real but sit outside HomeConnect's direct control or current operational scope, and aren't addressed here.